But NAAC director S.C. Sharma has rejected all allegations of irregularities, terming the entire assessment process robust, transparent and automated. "The system's integrity remains intact due to its decentralised nature, transparency and accessibility to stakeholders via a user-friendly portal and dashboard throughout all stages of the assessment and accreditation process," said Sharma.

In a statement, the NAAC also claimed that the Standardisation Testing and Quality Certification (STQC) had found its web application's security compliance status satisfactory in July 2022. Referring to the STQC, Patwardhan had written in his report: "Such cover-up attempts raise doubts regarding the possibility of a nexus (internal or external), which needs to be carefully examined." On the alleged discrepancies found by the CAG, Sharma said that even the NAAC has found several discrepancies in the CAG report. The report cannot be considered final, he asserted, claiming that a compliance reply issued by him was still under the CAG's consideration.

EVEN IN 2014, NAAC FACED ALLEGATIONS THAT GRADES OF SOME EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTES HAD BEEN INFLATED

That said, this is not the first time the NAAC has courted controversy. Back in 2014, several whistleblowers had alleged that grades of educational institutions were being inflated by tampering with the assessment reports submitted by expert panels. The National Education Policy, 2020, has set a target to get all HEIs to obtain the highest grading over the next 15 years, though the accreditation is still voluntary. As on January 31, only 38 per cent universities and 20 per cent colleges in India were NAAC-accredited. ■

UTTAR PRADESH

BJP'S MUSLIM PUSH

By Prashant Srivastava

While the Opposition accuses the Yogi Adityanath regime in Uttar Pradesh of letting his bulldozer run amok among members of the minority community and his ceaseless actions against mafia-turned-politicians Mukhtar Ansari, Atiq Ahmed and former minister Azam Khan, the state unit of the party is busy honing its strategy to woo the dominant Muslim castes in the run-up to the 2024 general election.

Accordingly, a series of events have been planned in the predominantly Muslim constituencies of western UP. The first of these events—'Sneh Milan: Ek Desh, Ek DNA Sammelan' (one nation, one DNA gathering)—will be held in April in Muzaffarnagar, which saw one of the worst post-Partition communal riots in 2013. In focus will be Muslim Rajputs, Muslim Jats, Muslim Gurjars and Muslim Tyagis.

Outlining the BJP strategy in the state, Kunwar Basit Ali, state president of the BJP Minority Morcha, tells INDIA TODAY: "These castes have a good equation with the Hindus in western UP and have significant numbers in the region." He claims that there are around 180,000 Muslim Rajputs in Saharanpur and another 80,000 in Muzaffarnagar. Muslim Gujjars number 100,000-odd in Shamli, and Muslim Jats an equivalent number in Muzaffarnagar. In all, Ali believes, there are nearly 200,000-250,000 Muslims of these four caste groups in every constituency where the community is dominant. And they're the target of the BJP's outreach efforts.

In these conferences, Ali reveals, the party will persuade Muslims to vest their faith in Hindu leaders from the Jat, Rajput, Gujjar and Tyagi communities. Invitation has also been extended to BJP leaders popular among these caste groups. These include defence minister Rajnath Singh (Thakur/Rajput), BJP state president Bhupendra Chaudhary (Jat), Union minister and Muzaffarnagar MP Sanjeev Balyan (Jat) and state minister



ONCE UPON A TIME CM Ashok Gehlot with Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat